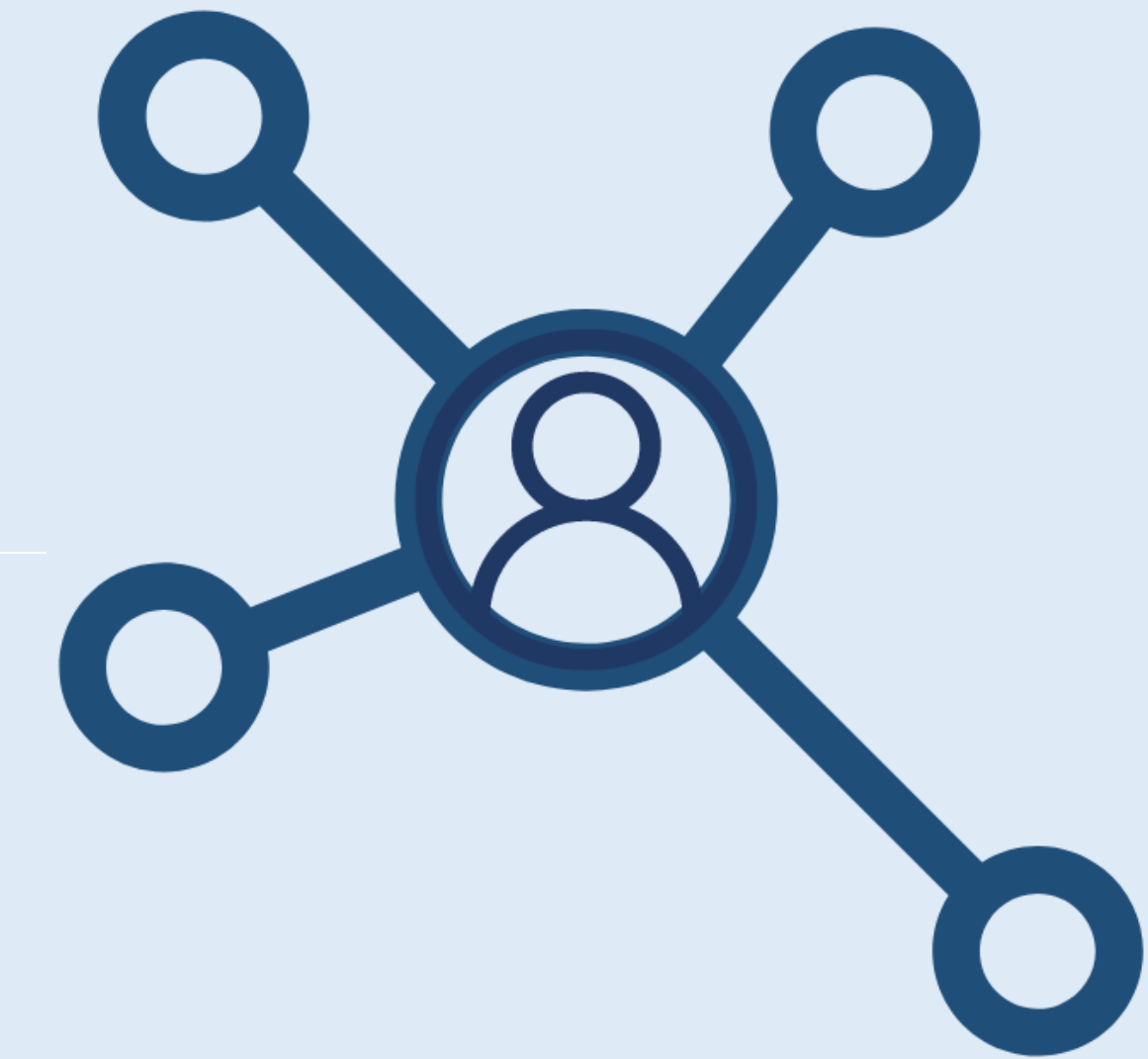




Welcome to Your New “Home”: Acculturation in First- and Second-Generation Immigrants



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Introduction & Objective

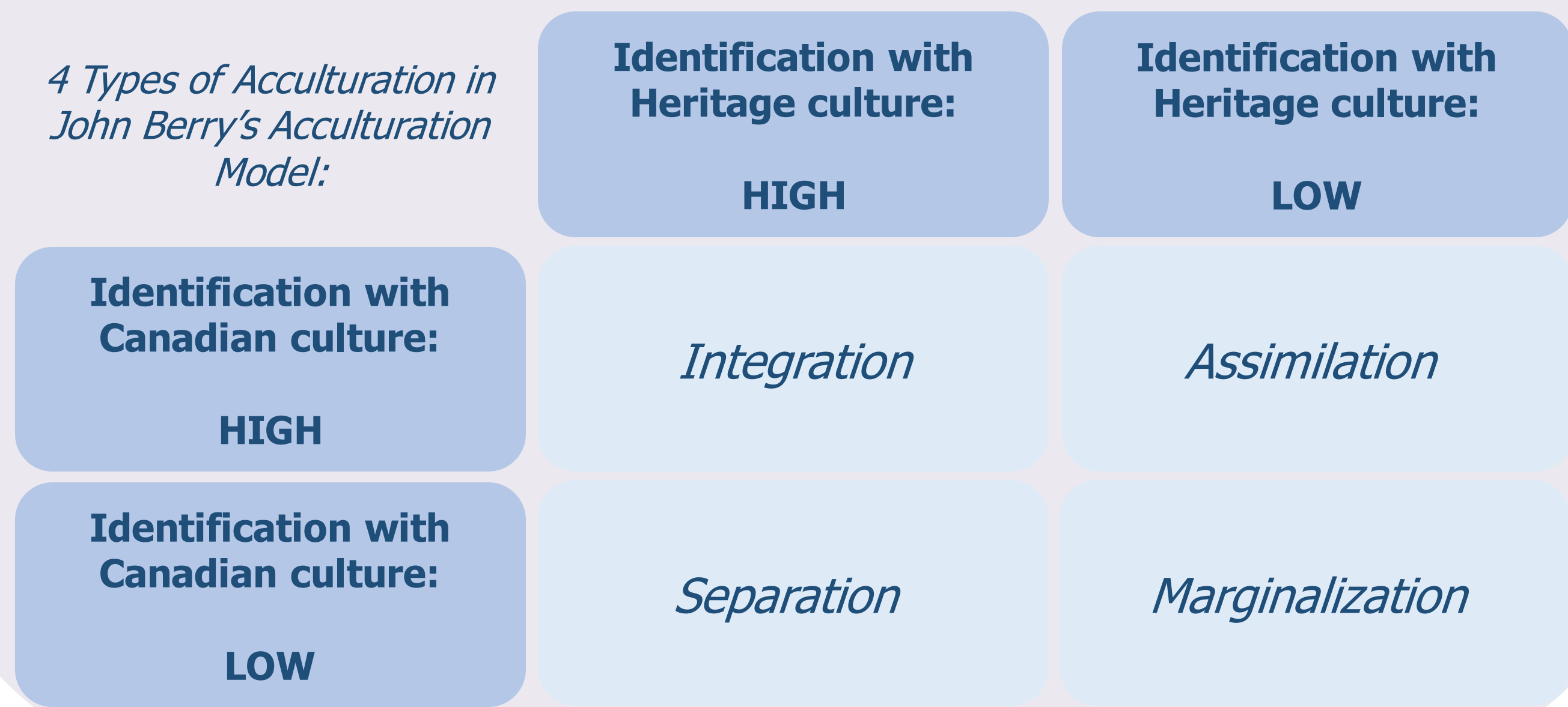
Immigrating to a new country is a complex and multifaceted journey that involves leaving behind one's familiar surroundings, culture, and social support networks to start a new life in an unfamiliar environment. The process of adjusting to a new culture and way of life can be particularly challenging, as individuals must balance the preservation of their cultural identity and values with the need to adapt to the cultural expectations of their new society.

The acculturation process, which involves finding a balance between one's cultural heritage and the dominant culture, is a critical aspect of this journey. John Berry's acculturation model is a well-known framework for understanding the acculturation process, which identifies four primary acculturation strategies: assimilation, integration, separation, and marginalization (Berry, 1992).

By examining survey data among first- and second-generation immigrants in Canada, this study seeks to understand how these individuals navigate the challenges of acculturation and build a new life in their new home. The study aims to provide insights into the complex interplay of factors that shape the acculturation experience for this population, including the impact of identity status, ethnic identity, and parent-child relationships.

Based on the literature review and theoretical framework, the study proposes the following hypotheses:

- Immigrants who have achieved a positive identity status (i.e., identity achievement) will be more likely to experience successful acculturation outcomes (i.e., integration) than those who have not.
- Immigrants who have strong familial connections will be more likely to experience successful acculturation outcomes (i.e., integration) than those who do not.
- Immigrants who have a positive perception of their ethnic identity will be more likely to experience successful acculturation outcomes (i.e., integration) than those who do not.

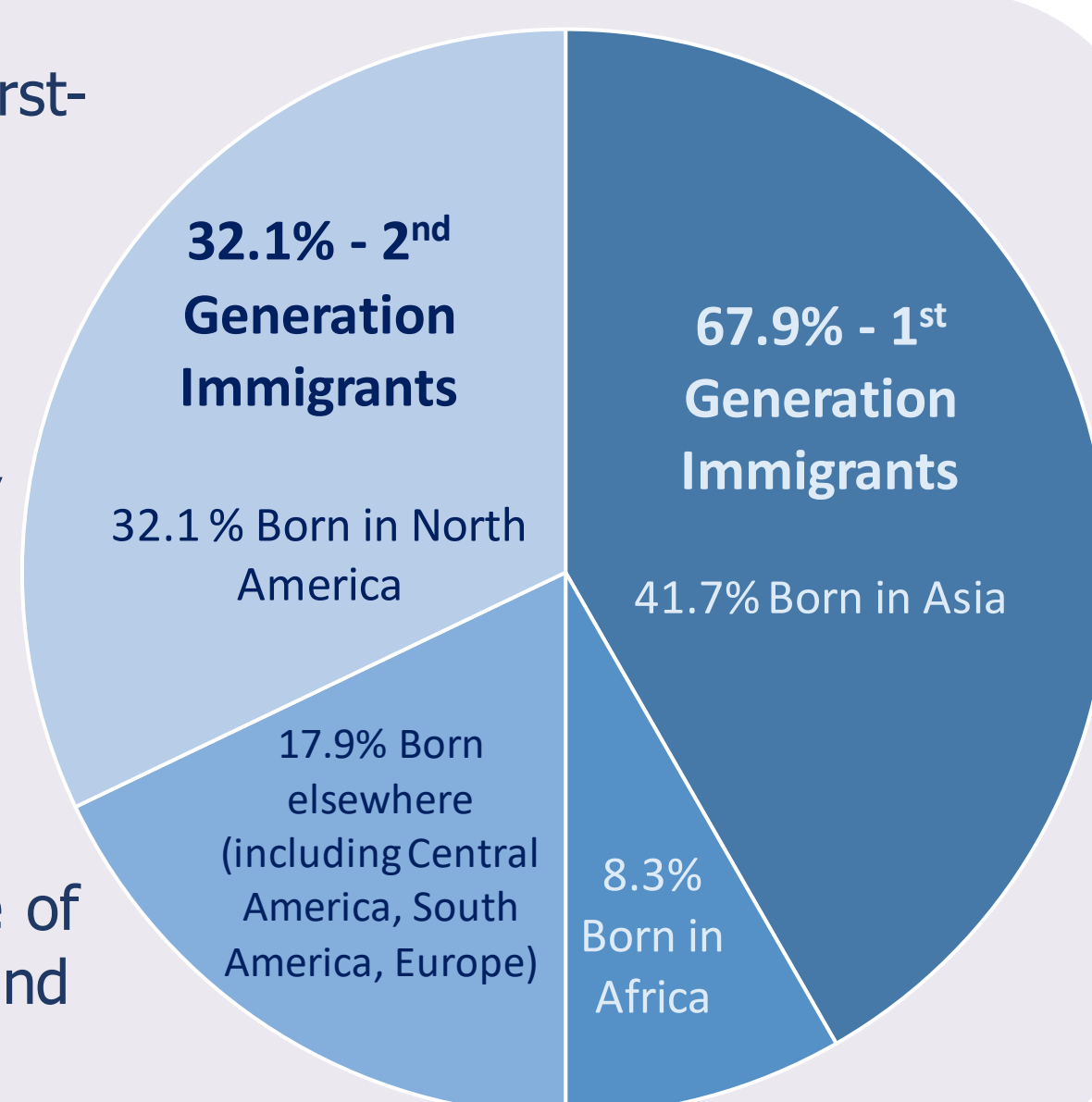


Participants

- Sample of 84 participants who self-identified as first- or second-generation immigrants in Canada.

- Participants (M age = 21.6 years, range = 18 to 45; 78.6% female) were recruited through Saint Mary's University's SONA system, online channels, and use of snowball sampling techniques.

- Participants were asked about their ethnicity; 46.4% identified as Middle Eastern, 16.7% identified as South Asian, 7.1% identified as Latin American, while a smaller percentage were native of Europe, West Asia, East Asia, Caribbean Islands and Pacific Islands.



Study Measures

The survey was administered online and consisted of a consent form and socio-demographic questions, followed by the completion of questionnaires. The questionnaires consisted of several measures to assess various aspects of acculturation and related constructs. Participants were instructed to answer each question honestly and to the best of their ability.

Child-Parent Relationship Scale: (Pianta, 1992)

- Conflicts – (i.e., “My parent(s) and I always seem to be struggling with each other”) – 12 items
- Closeness – (i.e., “If upset, I will seek comfort from my parent(s)”) – 10 items
- Dependence – (i.e., “I am overly dependent on my parent(s)”) – 4 items

(All items answered on a 5-point Likert scale (1=Definitely does not apply; 5=Definitely applies); 4 unscaled items; each subscale was created by averaging the items within each subscale.)

S-EMBU Scale: (Arrindell et. al, 1999)

- Rejection – (i.e., “My parents criticized me and told me how lazy and useless I was in front of others”) – 7 items
- Emotional Warmth – (i.e., “My parents praised me”) – 7 items
- (Over) Protection – (i.e., (“I sometimes wish my parents would worry less about what I was doing”) – 9 items

(All items answered on a 4-point Likert scale (1=No; 4= Yes, most of the time); 1 item reverse scored; each subscale was created by averaging the items within each subscale.)

Marcia's Identity Questionnaire: (Marcia, 1966)

- Achievement – (i.e., “It took me a while to figure it out, but now I really know what I want for a career”) – 10 items
- Moratorium – (i.e., “I'm still trying to decide how capable I am as a person and what jobs will be right for me”) – 10 items
- Foreclosure – (i.e., “I might have thought about a lot of different jobs, but there's never really any question since my parents said what they wanted”) – 10 items
- Diffusion – (i.e., “I'm not interested in finding the right job; any job will do. I just seem to flow with what is available”) – 10 items

(All items answered on a 5-point Likert scale (1=Strongly disagree; 5= Strongly agree); each subscale was created by averaging the items within each subscale.)

EAAM Acculturation Scale: (Berry, 2001)

- Assimilation – (i.e., “I write better in English than in my native language”) – 8 items
- Integration – (i.e., “I think as well in English as I do in my native language”) – 5 items
- Separation – (i.e., “My closest friends are people of my own ethnicity”) – 7 items
- Marginalization – (i.e., “There are times when I think no one understands me”) – 9 items

(All items answered on a 5-point Likert scale (1=Strongly disagree; 5= Strongly agree; Does not apply to me); each subscale was created by averaging the items within each subscale.)

Additional measures used in the study:

Measure of Religiosity:	Ten-Item Personality Inventory:	16-Item Horizontal & Vertical Individualism & Collectivism Scale:	Ethnic Identity Scale:
This measure assessed participants' level of religious involvement, beliefs, and practices.	This measure assesses the "Big Five" personality traits - openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism.	This measure assessed participants' cultural orientation towards individualism or collectivism.	This measure assessed participants' sense of belonging and identification with their ethnic group.

Results

Table 1.1:
Unstandardized Betas from the Multiple Regression (Hierarchical Entry) of Outcome Variables on Study Predictors.

DV: Assimilation	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3	DV: Integration	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3
Age	-.053	-.039	-.025	Age	.003	.004	-.005
Gender	.183	-.088	-.081	Gender	.267	.395	.351
Conflict		.288	.412	Conflict		-.136	-.270
Closeness		.292	.458*	Closeness		.640***	.573*
Dependence		-.756***	-.953***	Dependence		-.230	-.160
Rejection		.391	.464*	Rejection		-.019	.037
Emotional Warmth		-.214	-.130	Emotional Warmth		-.515*	-.612*
(Over) Protection		-.025	.189	(Over) Protection		.043	-.039
Achievement			-.288	Achievement			.420
Moratorium			.404	Moratorium			.122
Foreclosure			-.063	Foreclosure			.036
Diffusion			.248	Diffusion			-.043
R ²	.060	.315**	.409	R ²	.017	.276**	.320
R ² change	.060	.255**	.093	R ² change	.017	.259**	.044

*** p < .001
** p < .01
* p < .05

Results (continued)

DV: Separation	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3	DV: Marginalization	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3
Age	.030	.015	.014	Age	-.008	-.002	-.002
Gender	-.090	.306	.254	Gender	-.384	-.685	-.661
Conflict		-.309	-.298	Conflict		.010	.049
Closeness		.120	-.006	Closeness		-.626*	-.483
Dependence		.680***	.653**	Dependence		.019	-.049
Rejection		-.043	-.148	Rejection		.242	.316
Emotional Warmth		-.251	-.309	Emotional Warmth		.042	.051
(Over) Protection		-.233	-.237	(Over) Protection		-.097	-4.73E-5
Achievement			.180	Achievement			-.005
Moratorium			-.229	Moratorium			.237
Foreclosure			.387	Foreclosure			-.158
Diffusion			-.231	Diffusion			.365
R ²	.022	.282**	.347	R ²	.023	.255*	.302
R ² change	.022	.260**	.065	R ² change	.023	.232*	.046

Table 1.2:
Unstandardized Betas from the Multiple Regression (Hierarchical Entry) of Outcome Variables on Study Predictors.

*** p < .001
** p < .01
* p < .05

Hierarchical Multiple Regression

According to hierarchical multiple regression analyses, models in this study were found to be statistically significant:

- Assimilation – F (12,50) = 2.879, p < .004
- Integration – F (12,50) = 1.961, p < .049
- Separation – F (12,50) = 2.212, p < .025
- Marginalization – F (12,50) = 1.801, p < .074

Summary & Conclusion

Multiple regression analyses suggest that among first- and second-generation immigrants in Canada, an individual's familial connection and identity status hold unique predictive power for the following acculturation patterns: assimilation, integration, separation, and marginalization.

Regarding familial connection, Closeness positively predicted two patterns of acculturation: assimilation and integration. In other words, individuals who perceived warmth, affection, and open communication in their relationship with their parent(s) are associated with higher levels of assimilation and integration.

This suggests that when individuals have close and positive relationships with their parents, they are more likely to adopt aspects of the dominant culture and integrate them with their own cultural heritage. The warmth and affection that they feel in their familial relationships may help them to feel more comfortable and secure in exploring and incorporating new cultural practices and beliefs. Similarly, open communication with parents may provide a supportive and understanding environment for individuals to navigate their dual cultural identities and adapt to their new surroundings.

Furthermore, Dependence was positively correlated with one acculturation dimension: separation, while negatively correlated with another: assimilation. This implies that individuals who are heavily reliant on their family tend to experience greater separation in their acculturation journey and may struggle to assimilate into the dominant culture. In contrast, individuals who are less dependent on their family and have more opportunities for exposure to the dominant culture tend to be more open to adopting new cultural practices and beliefs, leading to a higher level of assimilation into mainstream society.

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